

Design Thinking Project Plan

UX 830 – Design for Interactivity | Summer 2026

Haris Omerovic omerovi5@msu.edu

00 Executive Summary

This project is one that I have been thinking of for a while. I intend to use the design thinking process to redesign the student-facing dashboard in D2L (Desire2Learn) specifically for students enrolled in asynchronous online courses. And of course it would/should be helpful for in-person students and professors as well. The goal is to design a clearer, more motivating dashboard experience that surfaces the right information at the right time.

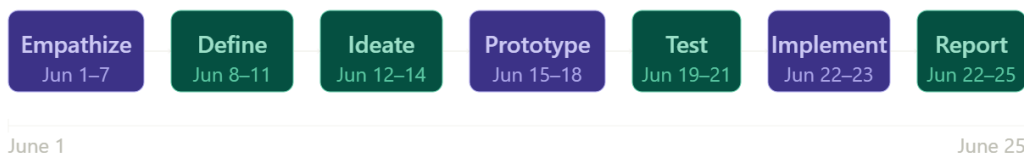
Hopes

- Students will have a clear, concrete pain point to rally around, making user research rich and focused.
- The D2L platform is familiar and accessible, so recruiting participants and gathering authentic reactions should be straightforward.
- A dashboard redesign has a well-scoped surface area, making it realistic to prototype and test within the timeline.
- Findings will have practical relevance to a real, widely-used platform—making the project feel meaningful.

Fears

- Recruiting enough participants for both research and testing phases within a compressed summer timeline.
- D2L's institutional constraints may limit how ambitious the design solution can be.
- Difficulty narrowing the problem—dashboard issues could branch into too many directions (navigation, notifications, progress tracking, etc.).
- Balancing depth of research with the pace required to hit all five DT steps before the deadline.

DT Roadmap



01 Step 1: Empathize

Start date: June 1, 2026

End date: June 7, 2026

Research Objectives

- To understand how students currently navigate and use the D2L dashboard in their day-to-day coursework.
- To identify the specific moments where students feel confused, anxious, or disoriented within D2L.
- To discover what information students most need at a glance but currently struggle to find.
- To learn how students mentally model course progress and deadlines.

Overview of Research Methods

- Secondary Research
- Unmoderated Task Observation (2 participants)
- Semi-Structured Interviews (4 participants)

Secondary Research

Review of peer-reviewed articles on online learner experience, UX audits of LMS platforms (D2L, Canvas, Blackboard), student success research, and any published usability reports on D2L.

Start date: June 1, 2026

End date: June 2, 2026

Time investment: 4 hours

Expected outcome: A baseline understanding of known D2L pain points and existing best practices in LMS dashboard design to inform interview questions and avoid redundant discovery.

Unmoderated Task Observation

Unmoderated. 20–30 minutes per participant. 2 participants complete typical D2L tasks (find what's due this week, navigate to a specific assignment, check grades) using a self-guided prompt sheet. Participants record their screen and narrate their actions using Loom or a similar tool and submit the recording asynchronously.

Participant Screening Criteria

- Currently enrolled in at least one asynchronous online course using D2L.
- Has used D2L for at least one full semester.

Recruitment Strategy

Reach out to classmates and contacts in other online programs. Post in relevant student channels on Discord servers. Target 2 participants to keep sessions manageable.

Assets to Prepare

- Self-guided task prompt sheet (3–4 tasks with clear instructions)
- Loom or screen recording setup instructions for participants
- Observation and note-taking guide for reviewing recordings

Prepare: 1.5 hours

Execute: 1 hour (reviewing 2 recordings)

Analyze: 1.5 hours

Expected outcome: Direct observation of real navigation behaviors, confusion moments, and workarounds students use when D2L doesn't meet their needs — gathered asynchronously without scheduling constraints.

Semi-Structured Interviews

Moderated. 30–45 minutes per session. 4 participants interviewed about their experience with D2L, how they track progress and deadlines, and what frustrates or helps them.

Participant Screening Criteria

- Currently enrolled in or recently completed an asynchronous online course using D2L.
- Mix of program types preferred (undergrad vs. grad, full-time vs. part-time).

Recruitment Strategy

Personal network, classmates in UXMS, and posts in student communities. Aim for 4 participants across 2–3 days to spread the workload.

Assets to Prepare

- Interview guide with 8–10 open-ended questions
- Consent/recording permission note
- Note-taking template organized by research objective

Prepare: 2 hours

Execute: 3 hours (4 sessions × ~45 min)

Analyze: 3 hours (affinity mapping, theme synthesis)
Expected outcome: Rich qualitative data on student mental models, emotional responses to D2L, and unmet needs that will directly feed persona and journey map creation.

02 Step 2: Define

Start date: June 8, 2026
End date: June 11, 2026

Outputs

- 2 Personas
- 1 Journey Map
- 1 Problem Statement (Point of View + How Might We questions)

Personas

Tool: Google Slides or Figma

Section headers

- Photo or illustration
- Bio (name, program, work/life context)
- Goals
- Frustrations
- D2L behaviors and habits
- Key quote

Time investment: 3 hours

Journey Map

Tool: Miro or Figma

Section headers

- Journey phases: Awareness → Orientation → Daily Use → Deadline Crunch → Outcome
- Steps
- Actions & touchpoints
- Feelings
- Research insights

- Pain points
- Moments of ease or delight
- Opportunities

Time investment: 3 hours

03 Step 3: Ideation

Start date: June 12, 2026

End date: June 14, 2026

Ideation Approaches

Crazy 8s

Objective: Generate a high volume of dashboard layout and feature ideas quickly without self-editing. Eight sketches in a few minutes each forces divergent thinking and surfaces concepts that slower, deliberate brainstorming misses.

How Might We + Dot Voting

Objective: Convert problem statement insights into actionable “How Might We” questions, then use dot voting to prioritize the most promising directions before committing to a prototype concept.

04 Step 4: Prototype

Start date: June 15, 2026

End date: June 18, 2026

Approach

Tool: Figma (lo-fi to mid-fi digital wireframes)

of Task Flows: 3–4 flows (e.g., “see what’s due this week,” “check my course progress,” “navigate to a missed announcement,” “find instructor feedback”)

Time investment: 10–12 hours

05 Step 5: Test

Start date: June 19, 2026

End date: June 21, 2026

Test Approach

Moderated usability testing. 30 minutes per session. 6 participants asked to complete task-based scenarios using the Figma prototype. Sessions conducted over Zoom with screen sharing. Feedback from all sessions will be collected first, then modifications applied after reviewing patterns across all participants.

Participant Screening Criteria

- Currently enrolled in or recently completed an asynchronous D2L course.
- Mix of prior D2L experience levels preferred (newer vs. experienced users).

Recruitment Strategy

Re-recruit 2–3 participants from the interview phase. Recruit 3–4 new participants via personal network or student communities to reach 6 total.

Assets to Prepare

- 3–4 task prompts (scenario-based, realistic)
- Evaluative metrics per task: ease-of-use rating (1–5), task completion (yes/no), number of hesitations or wrong clicks
- Discussion guide with follow-up questions per task
- Closing/debrief questions (overall impressions, what was missing, what helped)
- Note-taking template with columns for each task and metric

Prepare: 3 hours

Execute: 3.5 hours (6 sessions × ~35 min including setup)

Analyze: 3 hours (pattern synthesis, iteration decisions)

06 Step 6: Implement

Start date: June 22, 2026

End date: June 23, 2026

Implementation Plans

Tool: Figma — clickable hi-fi wireframe incorporating test feedback and applying a refined visual design to the dashboard.

Accessibility plan: Ensure sufficient color contrast (WCAG AA), readable font sizes, and clear visual hierarchy. Share the Figma prototype via a public link with view access so the instructor can open and interact with it on any device without needing a Figma account.

Time investment: 10–12 hours

07 Step 7: Reporting

Start date: June 22, 2026

End date: June 25, 2026

Reporting Plans

- Find or build a presentation template in Google Slides or Figma that matches the project's visual tone (clean, minimal).
- Journal briefly after each DT step—capture decisions made, what surprised you, and what you'd do differently. These notes feed directly into the report narrative.
- Draft the report structure by June 22 (overview, each step, key findings, prototype walkthrough, reflection).
- Solicit feedback from instructor or peers by June 23 to allow time for revisions.
- Finalize and submit by June 25.

Time investment: 10–12 hours